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Promised lands and paradisiacal gardens in Zoë Wicomb's *David's Story*

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ABSTRACT
Scholars such as Dorothy Driver have recognized Zoë Wicomb's *David's Story* as a novel that explores the uncertainties regarding the dawning of a democratic South Africa, especially as these pertain to coloured people, women, and anti-apartheid activists. Wicomb delves into these uncertainties through the novel's representation of land, which is portrayed as something the characters desire ownership of to achieve a sense of rootedness, belonging, and a self-contained racial identity. This article analyzes the novel's illustration of a would-be garden in a coloured neighbourhood, the Griquas's search for a promised land, and a majestic Scottish botanic garden. Although these topoi often connote notions of paradise, the article – drawing on Emmanuel Ngwira's use of Zygmunt Bauman's notion of "a gardening state" in his reading of Wicomb's *Playing in the Light* – interprets gardening as a metaphor to interpret the novel's treatment of violence exerted onto subjugated bodies through oppressive regimes or colonial science.

KEYWORDS
Zoë Wicomb; *David's Story*; coloured people; Griquas; land; garden

Introduction: The Cape garden and the genesis of the coloured population

Land remains a fundamental element in nationalist discourse. As James Graham (2009) argues, land has been mobilized throughout southern Africa in the 20th century "as a source of alternative *nationalist* narratives based on the desire for repossession" (2; emphasis in original), such that land has come to represent the nation. Regardless of the political shift occasioned by the institutionalization of democracy and the attendant focus on reconciliation, much literature in southern Africa "still registers anxiety over 'the land': over its ownership, resources and meaning" (6). Despite the transfer of the nation to Black majority rule following South Africa's first democratic election in 1994, land ownership has, for the most part, stayed the same and land continues to be a site of "contesting ideologies of belonging" (136). With the establishment of the Cape Colony, which, as Coetzee (1988) writes, was subject to the imperial myth of an Edenic garden (2), labouring the land was "prescribed" as a "remedy […] against Africa's insidious corruptions", which were assumed to manifest as idleness (3). A result of this history is that in the South African pastoral tradition, the labour of people of colour is generally

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erased, initiating a trend for white writing in the country: "If the work of hands on a particular patch of earth [...] is what inscribes it as the property of its occupiers *by right*, then the hands of black serfs doing the work had better not be seen" (5; emphasis in original). This misrepresentation of labour served to bolster the perceived "'natural' bond" (61) between white settlers and the land they usurped; the image of a new Garden of Eden that they manufactured was devoid of any labour other than their own and cast people of colour who laboured there as ineligible or illegitimate dwellers in the garden, despite their historical contribution to settlers' mythologizing of the Cape as a garden. In reality, the successful settlement of Europeans and the agricultural development of South Africa were actualized in large measure through the labour of people of colour, many of them slaves, and their descendants. This legacy continues in the present day, with many proletarian coloured people still labouring on white-owned farms and in suburban gardens, while continuing to live with the repercussions of historical land appropriations and forced removals.

The complexity of the relationship between South Africa's coloured population and the land they inhabit or labour upon is tantamount to the intricacies of their identity as a racial entity, from its inception at the Cape to the historical difficulty of defining the group and determining its members. In her essay, "Shame and Identity: The Case of the Coloured in South Africa", Zoë Wicomb (1998) avers that the varied changes in the appellation for coloured people throughout South African history "shows perhaps the difficulty which the term 'coloured' has in taking on a fixed meaning" (93). The origin of South Africa's coloured population, Mohamed Adhikari (2009) writes, can be traced to Dutch colonialism at the Cape and the subsequent creolization of various ethnic groups, including European settlers, indigenous Khoisan, and slaves of various diasporic origins (xi). Their group identity crystallized in the late 19th century, undergoing several name changes before the eventual implementation of the term "coloured" (xi). Despite its contentious history, the term "coloured" remains an established racial category in South Africa and is not regarded as derogatory as it is in other parts of the world. Nevertheless, as Wicomb acknowledges, there has been an enduring stigma around interracial relationships in the colonial Cape context, associated with the pejorative, pseudoscientific notion of "miscegenation", a term implying a flawed or abhorrent quality in those born from such relationships, which manifests in the association of colouredness with shame:

> Miscegenation, the origins of which lie within a discourse of 'race', concupiscence, and degeneracy, continues to be bound up with shame, a pervasive shame exploited in apartheid's strategy of the naming of a Coloured race, and recurring in the current attempts by coloureds to establish brownness as a pure category, which is to say a denial of shame. (Wicomb 1998, 92)

Consequently, as Zimitri Erasmus (2001) points out, the new dispensation has compelled some coloured people to re-conceptualize their racial identity, either to combat the ambiguity associated with inhabiting an intermediate position in apartheid's sociopolitical hierarchy, or to assert racial identity "based on claims to ethnicity and indigenous roots" (16). This grappling with coloured identity is an abiding feature of Wicomb's fiction.

Wicomb (2000) explores this incertitude and stigmatization around coloured identity in her novel *David's Story*. In it, she draws on – but substantially fictionalizes – the history of slavery at the Cape and the subsequent creation of South Africa's coloured population

through the saga of the Griqua people, a group of mixed Khoisan and European origin who migrated away from the Cape Colony in the 18th century, hoping to establish a state for themselves independent of European influence. In Wicomb's novel, the Griquas's journey takes them to Griqualand West, then over the Drakensberg to Kokstad in Griqualand East in the 1860s before they move to Beeswater in the Western Cape in 1922 under the leadership of Andrew Le Fleur (a fictional rendering of the actual Griqua Chief A.A.S. Le Fleur). Wicomb's dramatization of the Griquas's search for land upon which to establish themselves as an independent people is interwoven with a more recent history: the dismantling of the apartheid regime and the anticipation of South Africa's democratic period, which is portrayed primarily through the lives of David Dirkse and his wife Sally in the year 1991. It is through this alternating time frame that the novel addresses questions of land, nationhood, and belonging. The narrative shifts to moments from their past, including the couple's courtship as young operatives in MK (unMkhonto weSizwe, the paramilitary branch of the African National Congress). Anxiety about the future ignites David's interest in his family's Griqua origins – having heard stories as a child about the Griqua Chief, Andrew Le Fleur, from his paternal grandmother – and it sets in motion a journey that takes him from Cape Town to Kokstad, with the aim of producing a written history of his ancestors. He commissions an unnamed female amanuensis to write this history.

Since this article concentrates its interpretation of David's journey and that of his ancestors around the novel's horticultural illustrations, it expands the body of readings that have engaged with Wicomb's treatment of gardens in her fiction. In his reading of Wicomb's (2011) *Playing in the Light*, Emmanuel Ngwira (2016) focuses on the novel's utilization of the garden to demonstrate "the cultivation of whiteness" (186) in apartheid South Africa, while Brooke Stanley (2020) employs "garden-viewing" (69) in Wicomb's novel *October* (Wicomb 2014) and short story "In the Botanic Gardens" (Wicomb 1991) to reflect on the garden as a space of globalization. The present article argues that *David's Story* also utilizes gardens specifically (and land more broadly) to show how its coloured protagonists experience and conceive of their attachments to the land and, relatedly, their positionalities in an evolving, incipient democratic nation.

Land and history

At the time the narrative is set, uncertainty about the future of the coloured population, broadly speaking, and MK operatives specifically (as the novel shows, the credibility of their role in the anti-apartheid movement was being undermined, by evidence of atrocities committed against women underground), is introduced early on in the novel through descriptions of Sally's daily routines. A former cadre member alongside David, Sally is released from her activist work upon marriage and reluctantly adopts her new life as a wife and mother. Apprehensive about the prospect of a fresh start in the form of domestic life in a "house on the sandy Cape Flats", Sally consoles herself with the prospects of growing a garden, before abandoning the idea: "A garden would have been nice, but she soon gave up on that strip of coarse sand where marigold seedlings would wobble for a day or two like undernourished toddlers before keeling over for good" (Wicomb 2000, 16). The likening of wilting flowers to "undernourished toddlers" establishes Sally's initial domestic ineptitude in maternal terms. Although Sally found

that a fictitious domestic life with David during their covert MK work – involving "talk about Tracy", an imaginary child, "and blue kitchen cupboards" (14) – appealed to her as part of an undercover act, she finds what Meg Samuelson (2007) calls her "redomestication" (851) difficult, as her new life away from underground work has reduced her, in reality, to little more than an ordinary housewife. The temporary work she commences at a community centre leaves her with "an emptiness, a hollowness inside as if she had aborted, no, miscarried" (Wicomb 2000, 14). Sally's attempt at gardening reveals much about the difficulty of her new status, which might be elucidated through Wicomb's other writing.

Wicomb's ([1987] 2008) story "Ash on My Sleeve" in *You Can't Get Lost in Cape Town*, set in the early 1980s, also portrays a coloured family's garden in the Cape Flats. When Frieda Shenton, a coloured woman living in England, returns to Cape Town and visits Moira, a university friend, she observes "the porous sandy earth of the Cape Flats" (155). Having initially arrived at the wrong address, one where "the garden soil spills onto the pavement as if the earth were wriggling in discomfort" (155), Frieda later notes that Moira's garden is distinguishable from the other uniform homes by its neatness and "the determined effort" with which her husband, Desmond, attends to their garden: "Young trees grow in bonsai uniformity […]. The fence is efficient. The sandy earth does not escape; it is held by the roots of a brave lawn, knitting things together beneath the coarse grass" (156). This image of horticultural regularity masks Moira's chaotic domestic life as she seems overwhelmed by household and maternal responsibilities. Moreover, her blissful exterior conceals secrets: Desmond, a drinker who is uninterested in his wife's activities in the liberation movement, is unaware that she uses a playhouse in the backyard to provide refuge for Black people struggling with passes. In *David's Story*, Sally appears to face a similar predicament; as she applies herself to mundane household tasks, she uses strategies of concentration from her military training days, thinking "it has not all been wasted" (Wicomb 2000, 31). Cultivating a garden would have served her wider assertion of middle-class domesticity, her performance of normality, and the pretence of their having put down roots.

Sally's abandonment of the garden can also be read as symbolic of her philosophical rejection of David's search for his Griqua roots. When David laments to Sally that coloured people "don't know what [they] are" (Wicomb 2000, 29), she notes – perhaps disparagingly, perhaps sarcastically – that "the beauty of being coloured, [is] that [they] need not worry about roots at all, that it's altogether a good thing to start afresh" (27–28). A dissenting voice in David's quest, Sally claims that, for coloured people, "there's nothing to reclaim" and, dismissing a claim to indigeneity as a Griqua, she instead resigns herself to being, in her words, "a mixture of this and that" (28), a formulation of coloured identity that necessarily implies having shallow or insubstantial roots. Furthermore, Sally's initial longing for a domestic garden is thwarted by blighted soil, hindering her full aspirations for a novel domestic life. As with Desmond's garden, where the surrounding earth is "not ideal for the cultivation of prize-winning suburban dahlias" (Wicomb [1987] 2008, 155), the unproductiveness of the soil in Sally's community evokes the country's history of forced removals following the Group Areas Act of 1950; in particular, the relocation of coloured, Black, and Indian inhabitants to the Cape Flats, an atrophied landscape in comparison to the lusher suburbs closer to Table Mountain, where many removees originally lived. As Siona O'Connell (2019) points out, removees

were "dumped in inhospitable and unfamiliar townships", the names of which belie their actual sterility and bleakness: "Ocean View, Atlantis and Lavender Hill", among others, make a mockery of the residents' circumstances since "there are neither hills, views, lavender nor ocean vistas" (31). The inauspiciousness of Sally's garden is underscored by "the lowered eyes of white comrades who tutted and shook their heads in sympathy" for what she sees as a "comfortable" new home (Wicomb 2000, 16), revealing either their discomfort about forced removals or their awareness that significant improvement for coloured communities appears unlikely with the dawn of a new democratic era.

What Sally is deprived of is more than the ownership of a garden: it is also the practice of gardening, which is an exercise in personal autonomy; as Dan Wylie (2011) explains, it is "the pleasure, status and security of possessing your own patch of ground, over which you can take full control and exercise your gentrification and your creativity, your privacy and your love, your exclusions and inclusions" (73). Although brief, Wicomb's description of Sally's desire for a garden forms part of the novel's broader narrative of displacement and marginality, drawing historical connections with the impoverished soil that the Griquas repeatedly settle in their search for a piece of earth on which to reside as "natives in their own land" (Wicomb 2000, 90). Indeed, the description of Sally's failed attempt at gardening registers the denial of a degree of agency that a garden can afford (as Wylie argues) and severance of a connection to the land as a source of sustenance and identity that the broader coloured community and their ancestors had the benefit of historically.

As a literary motif, the garden adequately serves as a bearer of historical trauma derived from forced removals because, as Sarah Phillips Casteel (2003) explains, through its association with the Garden of Eden, the garden "almost inevitably recalls the themes of exile and displacement" (14). Delving into the memories of coloured people who were ejected from their Cape homes, Henry Trotter (2009) writes about the type of "commemoration narrative" (56) they construct, in which they tend to romanticize their former homes in prelapsarian terms:

> Removees often characterise their eviction in terms of a fall from a state of grace, though through no fault of their own. Their former communities were Edens compared to the postlapsarian townships. Following contours reminiscent of the story of Adam and Eve, removees plot their lives according to a narrative of descent. (57)

Through references to Eden, removee nostalgia posits the garden as a place of origins, one in which to establish roots. The Judeo Christian story of the Garden of Eden is, of course, also a story about the loss of innocence, with Adam and Eve's awareness of their nakedness appearing as a source of shame – in turn, a theme that emerges in *David's Story* in relation to interracial relationships, which the novel explores through ironic use of the term "miscegenation" (Wicomb 2000, 38).

Land and bloodlines

The aspiration of having a place to belong to, to own, and exert autonomy over – as Sally's garden exemplifies – appears elsewhere in the novel with the continual treks of the Griqua people. Much like their descendants in the Cape, who were forced out of lush suburbs into inhospitable ones, the Griquas faced pressure from British colonists after the discovery of diamonds in Griqualand West, with the region eventually annexed by the

British, forcing many Griquas to sell their farms. For Le Fleur, the blended racial background of coloured people dismantles fixity of place and group identity. When he announces his mission to establish "a grand Griqua race" instead of his people being "coloured nameless bastards" (Wicomb 2000, 146), he reveals the shame attached to colouredness; shame, as Wicomb explains, "located in the very word *Coloured*" as "defined negatively as 'not a White person or a Black'" by the apartheid government's Population Registration Act of 1950 (1998, 101; emphasis in original).

The Griquas's labouring of the land is integral to their settlement mission, but their travail is inspired by the misguided interpretation of biblical doctrine of their leader, Le Fleur, who presents himself as a prophetic chief.[1] Le Fleur's followers, self-identifying as "chosen people" but finding themselves "with nothing of their own", undertake several migrations to "b[e] led out of bondage" (Wicomb 2000, 85). They believe that their salvation is dependent on "tilling their own soil" (90) and, in search of "the Promised Land", they attempt to establish themselves "as a new nation" (97) in Beeswater. The promised land, like the garden – including the Garden of Eden – is a topos historically associated with the paradise myth as Sharae Deckard (2010, 6), explains. A further resonance between Sally's gardening attempt and those of the Griquas lies in the will to exert control over a terrestrial domain and, through it, establish a sense of order. However, when the memory of this inaugural moment is passed down to a young David from his grandmother, Ragel, who displayed "a photograph of the founding fathers of Beeswater" (Wicomb 2000, 99) on her dresser, the moment is remembered with pride. While Ragel claimed that it "was taken at the dabikwa tree, on the historic day of the Beeswater settlers' giving thanks to God" (99–100), in the narrative present David realizes that it was taken haphazardly, "some distance from the ceremonial tree" (100), the photographer having arrived late (two days after the historic day), thus underscoring the tenuousness of their assumed rootedness, despite the employment of biblical tropes to suggest otherwise. Such invocations of the biblical Israelites show the flimsiness of the Griquas's sense of belonging or attachment to the land because Le Fleur is compelled to rely on the typology of exodus rather than ancestral claims to specific areas of land (a point that adds credibility to Sally's later dismissal of Griqua identity as a means of securing rootedness for contemporary coloured people).

Revealing the impression that colouredness lacks a sense of authenticity or self-containment – mirroring apartheid's reductive conceptualization of blackness and whiteness as "given, coherent and homogeneous identities" (Erasmus 2001, 15) – and promulgating the view that racial homogeneity would emanate from embeddedness in a particular place – Le Fleur reasons that the coloured population's lack of racial purity or authenticity accounts for his people's displacement. He attempts to assert a state of Griqua "purity" – purity being conceptualized as akin to racial homogeneity, corresponding to the views underpinning apartheid-era legislation – as if to undo the ramifications of colonial contact and racial hybridity, which are the reasons for his rejection of colouredness. The irony of Le Fleur's assurance that, as Griquas, they "will wipe out the stain of colouredness and gather together under the Griqua flag those who have been given a dishonourable name" (Wicomb 2000, 42) is that the Griquas are themselves the product of interracial mixing between Europeans and the indigenous Khoisan.

While Le Fleur can recognize European prejudice towards Griqua and coloured people, his opinion that the latter are without a culture and history of their own

demonstrates his internalization of the European bias to which he objects. Moreover, he attempts to rectify this perceived shortcoming of coloured people by establishing his followers as Griquas, as a people with a self-contained history and identity, by mythologizing them and their exodus. This mission appears oddly to mirror the rhetoric of Afrikaner nationalism in the early 20th century, which also relied on historical invocations of wandering Israelites, analogizing the Great Trek as an escape to a promised land, as Dorothy Driver (2001) points out, and self-characterizing as chosen people. Afrikaner nationalism frequently appealed to the allure of *eiesoortigheid*, a principle of distinctiveness or, in P. Eric Louw's (2004) words, "own-ness" by which "each 'group' was to have its own 'space'" (320), implying both spatial segregation, and cultural and ethnic separateness. It is therefore apparent that Le Fleur's separatist project corresponds with the burgeoning apartheid-era legislation.

To make his inconsistent views about racial purity plausible, Le Fleur decides to ignore his diasporic origins, with the narrator explaining that "of his own European ancestry, well, that blood was by now so thin, so negligible, there really was no need to take it into account" (Wicomb 2000, 88). Le Fleur's equating of colouredness with "stain" and "a dishonourable name" echoes Wicomb's (1998) essay in its explanation that shame is located in the name "coloured" because of its history. Le Fleur reinforces the idea of shame around "miscegenation" because it recalls the long-standing evolution of the terms used to identify both Griqua and coloured people and the difficulty implied by that evolution, given their complex genealogy, to definitively categorize them as a people. Disregarding his hypocrisy, Le Fleur renounces the coloured population's existence as being unanchored in South Africa but overlooks the fact that the Griquas do not pursue their various treks by their own volition but are instead continually subjected to coercive measures of relocation as well as their leaders' fickleness. In fact, instead of producing a fruitful and sustainable settlement, their relocations culminate in ever-deteriorating conditions in which to work, much like the conditions that Sally would later confront. Although Wicomb's depiction of the Griquas's continual toil in their numerous failed attempts at yielding prolific land presents a retort to the Eurocentric depiction of indigenous labourers as indolent, and while Griqua industriousness in *David's Story* can be seen as an attempt to re-inscribe "Black hands" into the literature of settlement in South Africa, the series of displacements that they are subject to produces precisely the kind of idleness to which Le Fleur objects. Their laborious but futile work is later emulated in Le Fleur's drudgery after British colonial officials sentence him to 14 years of hard labour on Robben Island, likened to the punitive labour meted out to political prisoners during apartheid (Driver 2001, 225). This comparison – the image of unavailing labour – offers a despairing prospect for someone like David, who fought for a new nation but feels uncertain about the outcome of his efforts.

Moreover, in the context of colonial Cape society and the kinds of relationships that gave rise to the coloured population, "miscegenation" carries with it the connotation of illegitimacy. In writing about the evolution of racial nomenclature applied to the Griquas in his analysis of Le Fleur's denigration of coloured people as "nameless bastards", Mike Marais (2005) points to the fact that the word "bastard" "in the Cape Dutch society of the 18th century [...] signified both hybridity and illegitimacy" to denote the progeny of white male settlers and Khoi women, born from "casual, hypergamous miscegenation, rather than inter-marriage" (22). The notion of illegitimacy – and its association with

shame and "miscegenation" – is underscored by the novel's reference to Sarah Gertrude Millin's (1924) novel *God's Stepchildren*, one of the texts the novel critiques, which portrays interracial relationships and those who are a product of them as sinful, deplorable, adulterated, and calamitous. The colonial-era belief that interracial mixing led to an innate character flaw is apparent in colonial-era views of indigenous groups, as Coetzee (1988) described in *White Writing*, and apartheid-era stereotypes about coloured people (common in literature by 20th-century Afrikaner writers), as presented in Vernon February's (1981) *Mind Your Colour: The "Coloured" Stereotype in South African Literature*.

David's father, Dawid, worried about what others will think of them, views the former's abandonment of a career as a teacher to join the anti-apartheid movement as evidence of him "giv[ing] coloureds a bad name" (Wicomb 2000, 21). When Dawid bemoans the fact that his sacrifices for David's education and eventual career as a school principal have, to his mind, been in vain, he asks: "What has been the fruit of my labour but shame? Yes, it's like a tree in the front garden just laden for all to see with the shiny apples of my shame" (21–22). By formulating his dejection with an image of an apple tree as a bearer of shame, Dawid suggests another biblical reference, this time to the tree of the knowledge of good and evil in the Garden of Eden (the apple being the fruit commonly associated with Adam and Eve's temptation), according to which one can interpret Dawid's dismay at David's apparent disobedience to his father as the root cause of the Dirkse family tree being, in Dawid's view, corrupted. The shame surrounding interracial relationships, when perceived as "miscegenation", is apparent throughout *David's Story* in the attitude, demonstrated by several characters, that qualities or activities that racist apartheid discourse associated with coloured and Griqua people – in Dawid's words, "the coloured condition – drunk, lawless, uncivilised" (22) – ought to be shorn off in favour of the pretensions of the coloured petty bourgeoisie (see Adhikari 1994, 101–108). Dawid's accusations about drunkenness and lawlessness exaggerate the influence that the movement has had on David, but they point to Dawid's need to maintain their position of relative privilege within the racial hierarchy of apartheid society and to avoid being involved in activities that might jeopardize that position. Dawid's perspective reveals how the coloured petty bourgeoisie clung to notions of respectability – antithetical to shame (Erasmus 2001, 13) – which manifests in the value attached to proficiency in English, class consciousness, and aspirations towards whiteness, both in perceived affectations and in physical appearance (coveting straight hair and fair skin).

Respectability politics, as Margot Dazey (2021) defines it, is "a form of social control" between members of a marginalized group, imposed by those enjoying relative privilege within the group – influenced by the dominant culture – who normalize certain "behaviors as desirable" (582), thereby distinguishing themselves from those in the group who fail to emulate these norms. Dawid's wish for David to become a school principal – a well-regarded profession for coloured people during apartheid, as Daniel Hammett (2008, 343) contends – as well as the many instances of the anglicization of family names in subsequent generations (David from Dawid, Rachael from Ragel, Sally from Sarie) correspond to the novel's tongue-in-cheek view of "a respectable coloured home" and its values (Wicomb 2000, 117). Concerns about respectability are reflected in David's family's awareness of their tenuous position of relative privilege. This position is made clear by Dawid reproaching David for "mess[ing] around with" Black people in the

movement, referring to them in this exchange with a racial slur (Wicomb 2000, 19). Dawid's attitude lends credence to the view, as Hammett asserts, "that [for many] respectability and resistance to the apartheid state were mutually exclusive" (2008, 342). Since respectability emphasizes, among other things, a sense of orderliness and status (341–342), Dawid's desire for his child to secure a steady middle-class existence can be interpreted as a wish to secure his place in a society where the social standing of coloured people is precarious; a career as a teacher and a future position as school principal will, like a well-tended home garden, help to validate this position.

What Dawid fears is that David's involvement in politics threatens to subvert the established order of their society in which coloured people occupy a supposedly natural position above Africans. This explains why, when Sarie (Sally's mother) sees Nelson Mandela during a political rally in Cape Town in the narrative present, she considers him "a fine-looking gentleman" who "must have good coloured blood in him" (Wicomb 2000, 207). Sentiments such as this, which claim blood or race as a natural marker of difference and an indication of propriety, were integral to apartheid's segregationist logic, including its aversion to interracial relationships perceived as miscegenation. Martín Premoli (2020) explains the rationale in this way:

> The idea of propriety – and of things having a proper place – was conducive to apartheid's emphasis on boundaries, in which the clean and proper refer to that which is kept within socially acceptable boundaries set by the dominant socioeconomic order in a society. (57)

This conviction "of things having a proper place" is relatable to *David's Story*'s exploration of colonial science, which forms part of the novel's ironizing of order, systematization, resoluteness, and finitude. This is shown in its fragmentary structure, half-told stories, the amanuensis's fabrications to amend for David's caginess, and its complications of the truth, as Wicomb discusses in an interview with Thomas Olver and Stephan Meyer (Wicomb 2004, 133–134). These are qualities that have led scholars like Driver to assert that the novel grapples with "the politics of representation" (2001, 231), "the impossibility of true origins" (243–244), the difficulty of producing meaning (251) or establishing "authoritative positions" (253). These issues are tied up with the novel's depiction of bodies, especially the bodies of women of colour, subjected to various forms of violence in the name of such varied enterprises as medical science and liberation movements; issues that coalesce in the novel's depiction of a Scottish botanic garden.

Land and bodies

In his reading of *Playing in the Light*, Ngwira employs Zygmunt Bauman's ([1989] 2000) metaphor of the modern nation state in *Modernity and the Holocaust* as a garden to reflect on the way apartheid society enforced a sense of order that segregated the races. Ngwira explains, quoting from Bauman, that "the modern state becomes 'a gardening state' whose population comprises 'useful plants to be encouraged and tenderly propagated, and weeds – to be removed or rooted out' " (Ngwira 2016, 186). He does so to illustrate "the cultivation of whiteness" (186) in the lives of the Campbells, a coloured family passing as white during apartheid, and argues that the presence of weeds in the family garden is indicative, symbolically, "of the family's repressed coloured history" (184). This analogyzing of coloured communities with weeds is also applicable to *David's*

Story and the forced removals alluded to in the description of Sally's home since, as Tim Cresswell (1997) notes, weeding is an example of "metaphors of displacement" (330), premised on the idea that "many plants become weeds simply by being in the wrong place" (335). The intercultural contact and exchange that produced South Africa's coloured population was "facilitated" by the Company's Garden at the Cape (Ngwira 2016, 185), established by the Dutch East India Company, which supports the view of the garden as a space of creation and origin but also, as Casteel (2003, 14) argues, of hybridity. However, political mechanisms that scholars have metaphorized as weeding and the neatening of a garden elucidate a state's ability to excise undesirable elements within the body politic, subduing and containing said hybridity. The image of weeding illuminates apartheid South Africa's forced removals of "surplus communities", characterized as dirt or waste, and pushed to the fringes (see Wenzel 2018). Policies that enforce such displacement are underpinned, as Bauman ([1989] 2000, 68–70) explains and as Ngwira (2016) also points out, by Enlightenment ideals, by the impetus to impose order on the external world, to systematize, sort through, and name. The same ideals underpinning natural history and scientific exploration have been complicit in imperial undertakings, as Mary Louise Pratt (2008) has shown: "Natural history conceived of the world as a chaos out of which the scientist *produced* an order" (30; emphasis in original). This "systematization of nature coincide[d] with the height of the slave trade, the plantation system, colonial genocide in North America and South Africa" (35). The drive to establish order in the natural world, to create "a gardening society", functioned as a harbinger of various forms of social impositions and political subjection including those implemented in South Africa for much of the 20th century.

Ventures in exploration and colonial expansion were spurred on by the paradise myth; following Europeans' 15th-century appropriation of American colonies, paradise discourse facilitated their exploitation of material resources and the way they "imagine[d] and dominate[d] the Others whom they encountered" (Deckard 2010, 7). *David's Story* points to the relationship between colonial history and paradise through its inclusion of a well-known botanic garden – a space imbued with connotations of paradise and Eden (Deckard 2010, 11) – in David's recollection of a visit to the People's Palace and Winter Gardens during a trip to Glasgow in the 1980s (in a cohort of teachers but also to conduct covert MK work). His recognition that the glasshouse shelters "the familiar Cape flora of palm trees, begonia, poinsettia, hibiscus, and strelitzia" (Wicomb 2000, 189) intimates forms of exchange and displacement and the complicity of the natural sciences in colonial enterprises. The gardening metaphor as a means of control over subjugated bodies is illustrated when, at the People's Palace, David detects the barely visible face of a Black man in a painting of John Glassford, the Scotsman who owned plantations in Maryland, and his children, "circa 1767" – a painting showing "an abundance of flowers" (191). Recognition of the Black servant inserts the realities of the slave trade into an otherwise innocent pastoral image and underlines the novel's stance on the brutalization of people of colour during colonial and apartheid rule.

David's Glasgow visit is related to the novel's references to Sara Baartman, the Khoi woman born in South Africa in the 1770s and taken to Europe where she was paraded, exhibited and "studied", and where, upon her death in 1815, her body was dissected by Georges Cuvier, the renowned scientist and anatomist. Bauman's expansion of the image of the nation-as-garden to include "the medical metaphor" offers insight into such

treatment, as he explains that "one can train and shape 'healthy' parts of the body, but not cancerous growth. The latter can be 'improved' only by being destroyed" (Bauman [[1989] 2000, 65). Although the amanuensis decides not to include Baartman in David's history of the Griquas, her treatment by Cuvier is presented as foreshadowing the physical torture of Dulcie, a fellow MK cadre member, by misogynistic male comrades, both in and out of their training camps. David's evasiveness in response to the amanuensis's questions about her suggests his knowledge of – and perhaps even involvement in – Dulcie's torture. Dulcie, as Ken Barris (2010) argues, "recuperates the figure of […] Baartman" with regard "to the colonial scientific discourse" and to the way this recuperation is linked to "a more contemporary marginalization, namely that of coloured women within the anti-apartheid struggle" (33). That Dulcie's torture, as Derek Attridge (2005) writes, "seem[s] so like a surgical operation" (163) accentuates the role of medical science in questions of race; drawings in the novel of Dulcie's mutilated body, against the narrative backdrop of forced removals, enable one to connect the treatment of subjugated bodies to the geographical dismemberment of those deemed by authorities as disposable.

The connection between Dulcie's torture and the experience of slavery is made explicit through allusions to Toni Morrison's (1987) *Beloved*, a neo-slave narrative that Dulcie reads, in turn emphasized by David's identification of her as "the beloved" (Wicomb 2000, 116). Wicomb's narrator evokes the image of the formation of physical scars on the slave Sethe's back in Morrison's book – the result of brutal beatings – that, to Sethe's mind, resemble a chokecherry tree, with Dulcie admiring that Sethe "nevertheless is able to turn [the scars] into a tree" (19). Although indicative of Dulcie's defiance in the face of her torture, this is an ironic view of trees in a slave-holding society since they were often used for restraining and lynching slaves. With such reprehensible arboreal images, Wicomb connects colonial exploits to the torment inflicted upon Dulcie intended to force her into submission, and to ensure her obedience, an indication of the abuses perpetrated in the name of freedom. It serves to signal Wicomb's trepidations surrounding the status of women of colour in the New South Africa, suggesting that it will not develop into a working democracy attuned to the various dimensions of inequality in society, validating race and gender as terrain for democratic promise.

However, Wicomb also questions the plausibility of this terrain near the novel's end when the amanuensis sits by her window and, looking out at her garden, sees – or imagines seeing – "[Dulcie's] sturdy steatopygous form on the central patch of grass, where she has come to sunbathe in private. She is covered with goggas [insects] crawling and buzzing all over her syrup sweetness, exploring her orifices, plunging into her wounds" (Wicomb 2000, 212). Soon thereafter, in a way reminiscent of the clandestine nature of militants' operations, a shadowy figure is seen jumping over the wall, before lodging a bullet into the amanuensis's laptop, destroying the story, David's story, she is busy writing.

This vision of a maimed Dulcie that is simultaneously carnal and putrid prompts the amanuensis to ponder: "Is this no longer my property? […] I have never thought of Dulcie as a visitor in my garden" (Wicomb 2000, 212). The amanuensis's walled domestic garden recalls "the Zoroastrian notion of the enclosed garden", the space from which the notion of paradise originates (Deckard 2010, 4), but the fact that its boundaries are violated by Dulcie and the unknown figure who leapt over the wall suggests that the garden no longer represents a safe and sanctified space but rather a fallen world. The

destruction of the laptop and the undoing of the amanuensis's narrative signal the "dispens[ing] with an author, authority, all forms of control" (Driver 2010, 533); the unravelling of the impetus, born of the Enlightenment and exemplified by the garden, of order and mastery. No longer does Dulcie's body showcase torture with surgical precision; her wounds appear excessive and unrestrained. That it is Dulcie, a type of narrative revenant of Baartman, who is visualized in such a state in the garden implies that the landscape is still haunted by the history of pernicious violence, both in the context of colonialism and the liberation movement, and that the garden – now reverting into a wilderness – fails, as evident in Sally's experience, to be a space of new beginnings.

Conclusion: Racial divisions and the garden ideal

David's search for his roots ends unaccomplished; his body washes ashore in the vicinity of Chapman's Peak, the result of a possible suicide, with the implication that he is tormented by his own complicity in, or guilt over, Dulcie's torture. This drowning is the very antithesis of the sought-after attachment to land that drives the novel. Following the typology of exodus discussed earlier, in which land is to be conquered to establish order, water represents the opposite: chaos and disorder, a state before creation. In tracing the origins of South Africa's coloured population, *David's Story* challenges the myth of the paradisiacal garden or promised land and ideas around "own-ness" that they embody. Wicomb depicts a garden ideal premised on rigid racial divisions and seemingly inflexible social strata, one which remains inaccessible to communities with histories of racial intermixing, thus complicating efforts of national belonging. The novel ultimately metaphorizes gardening through a concatenation of historical endeavours – from colonialism and slavery to apartheid and the subsequent liberation movement – to demonstrate the control and violence imposed on the bodies of subjugated peoples.

Notes

1. The real Le Fleur viewed himself and was regarded by his community as a providential visionary (see Edgar and Saunders 1982, 145; Wicomb and Willemse 2002, 205). *David's Story*'s description of an incident when a young Le Fleur is sent by his father to fetch two mules that had strayed from the barren is an allusion to the biblical story of King Saul, a comparison that stresses the novel's characterization of Le Fleur as prophetic but stubborn.

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